UNCLASSIFIED // OPEN SOURCE ACADEMIC ANALYSIS

STRAIT OF HORMUZ

INTEGRATED STRATEGIC ASSESSMENT

Regional Posture · Partner Architecture · Long-Term Control · Diplomatic Resolution · Great-Power Mineral Framework · Coalition Sustainment · Post-Seizure Phase Assessment

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Series Relationship	WP-2026-HORMUZ-01 = foundational posture assessment. WP-2026-HORMUZ-02 = integrated campaign architecture built on that posture logic. HORMUZ-02 presupposes HORMUZ-01 but is independently legible. Reviewers unfamiliar with HORMUZ-01 should treat Parts I–II of this document as the posture summary.
Version History	v1.0: Posture/partner architecture. v2.0: Diplomatic framework, branch scenarios, KPIs, proxy risk. v3.0: Great-power mineral framework, IRGC targeting doctrine, civilian differentiation, leadership justification. v4.0: Evidentiary calibration, confidence lexicon, friction acknowledgment, documented/modeled boundary discipline. v4.1: Hostile stress test hardening — mineral framework temporal displacement, composite IRGC proxy verification, Gulf Maritime Forum Helsinki disanalogy, civilian differentiation integration acknowledgment, Oman/India/Track-1 secondary patches, Part X post-seizure Kharg assessment.
Status	FINAL HARDENED DRAFT — Post hostile stress test. Submitted for analytical review.

NOTICE: Open-source academic and strategic analysis only. No classified information. All assessments are drawn from published literature, government reports, and established policy analysis organizations. Legal analysis is for analytic framing only and does not constitute legal advice.

METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

ANALYTIC POSTURE STATEMENT	*This document is a conditional scenario architecture, not a prediction. It models what a synchronized multi-instrument Hormuz stabilization campaign could look like under stated premises, and assesses the plausibility of each mechanism under those premises. It does not predict that stated outcomes will occur, that timelines will be met, or that partners will behave as modeled. Every claim is graduated by the confidence levels defined below. Thresholds and KPIs are illustrative analytic benchmarks for scenario evaluation, not operational commitments or forecasts. This analysis does not incorporate classified intelligence, internal government planning, or non-public diplomatic communications. All sourcing is open-source and is evaluated at the tier levels defined in the reference section.*

Confidence Lexicon

The following terms are used consistently throughout this document. All confidence-labeled claims should be interpreted against these definitions.

Term	Definition
HIGH CONFIDENCE	Claim is directly supported by multiple independent Tier 1 or Tier 2 sources with consistent findings. Analytic inference is minimal.
MODERATE CONFIDENCE	Claim is supported by credible Tier 1 or Tier 2 sourcing but involves meaningful analytic inference or contains a significant unresolved variable. Stated uncertainty may affect the conclusion.
LOW CONFIDENCE	Claim rests primarily on analytic inference from limited or indirect evidence. Reasonable alternative conclusions exist. This label does not mean the claim is wrong — it means the evidentiary basis is thin and the conclusion should be held provisionally.
SCENARIO-CONDITIONED	Claim or projection is valid only under the stated scenario premises. It is not a prediction of what will happen, but an assessment of what the architecture implies if premises hold.
ANALYTICALLY INFERRED	Claim is derived by logical extension from documented premises, not directly observed. The inference is assessed as sound but depends on the validity of underlying premises.
SNAP-BACK (analytic scope)	Snap-back mechanisms referenced in this document are assessed as structurally available and legally grounded. Their political activation is scenario-conditioned and depends on coalition consensus that cannot be guaranteed in advance. Snap-back is an analytic enforcement tool, not a guaranteed political outcome.

Documented / Modeled Boundary Convention

This document distinguishes between two categories of content that may otherwise read as equivalent:

- Documented open-source observation: events, conditions, or data reported by named Tier 1 or Tier 2 sources. These are labeled with source tier at point of use. They describe what is reported, not what is verified independently.
- Modeled architecture: forward-looking mechanisms, sequencing, conditionality structures, and partner behavior projections derived by analytic inference from documented premises. These are labeled ANALYTICALLY INFERRED or SCENARIO-CONDITIONED as appropriate.

Where a section blends both, transition language marks the boundary explicitly: 'documented open-source reporting indicates...' precedes empirical claims; 'the following analysis assumes...' or 'under that premise, the architecture projects...' precedes modeled content.

How to Read This Document

Parts I–IV: Military posture, partner architecture, and integrated timeline. Read these for force disposition and coalition structure. Parts V–VI: Diplomatic resolution sequence and branch scenarios. Read these for sequencing logic and contingency structure. Part VII: Proxy and multi-front risk. Read this for concurrent threat vector management. Part VIII: Conditional great-power mineral trade framework. Read this for economic statecraft instruments. Part IX: Final assessment and synthesis. Each part is modular. Companion papers (MAXPRESS-01, UNIFIED-01, CONTAIN-01, INFRA-01) carry statutory authorities, sanctions enforcement sequencing, and financial isolation architecture referenced but not reproduced here.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

CORE JUDGMENT [MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE]	*The analytically favored architecture is a phased military-to-diplomatic transition: a distributed reinforced posture creates security conditions for a multilateral diplomatic framework transitioning over 1–5 years to a GCC-led maritime security architecture underpinned by a self-enforcing institutional framework. U.S. control is structural — embedded in reconstitution triggers, snap-back mechanisms, and tiered conditionality — not dependent on permanent forward presence. The coalition holds through differentiated value exchange: each partner sustains its contribution because it serves that partner's national interest to do so. All timelines and thresholds in this document are scenario-conditioned analytic benchmarks, not predictions or operational commitments.*

Scenario Premise

This assessment proceeds from the scenario premise, supported by cited open-source reporting evaluated at the confidence levels indicated throughout, that Iranian actions beginning on or around March 2, 2026 produced a partial disruption of normal commercial transit patterns in and around the Strait of Hormuz. [TIER 2 OPEN-SOURCE BASIS — Axios, Atlantic Council, EIA March 2026 reporting; confidence in specific closure details is MODERATE given dependence on real-time commercial and journalistic sourcing that has not been independently verified by this analysis.]

The architecture developed in this document is downstream of that scenario premise. Assessments that depend most heavily on this premise are labeled SCENARIO-CONDITIONED throughout. Mechanisms that would remain analytically valid under alternative crisis scenarios are labeled ANALYTICALLY INFERRED.

U.S. Leadership Rationale

The U.S. case for leading this architecture rests on three factual assessments, not normative claims. First, documented open-source reporting indicates the United States is the only actor with MCM capacity deployable at scale on the 0–90 day timeframe — no GCC partner or coalition ally can substitute for this function in the surge window. Second, the United States is the only actor whose alliance network spans all relevant partners simultaneously — GCC states, Israel, NATO allies, and Asian partners — making the U.S. the only viable de-confliction node for a coalition with structurally incompatible public postures. Third, the long-term U.S. interest is a rules-based transit regime, not a bilateral arrangement amenable to renegotiation by future Iranian governments or great-power alignment shifts. These are capability and interest assessments. They do not require American exceptionalism as a premise and are durable across administrations with divergent values.

The commitment to partner prosperity embedded in this framework is structural, not altruistic. GCC economic stability, Asian energy security, and European LNG continuity are U.S. strategic interests because their disruption creates second-order costs the U.S. absorbs through allied

economic instability, coalition fragmentation, and reduced partner burden-sharing capacity. Any administration that is strategically rational will sustain this architecture.

PART I: LONG-TERM HORMUZ CONTROL ARCHITECTURE

The following section draws on documented open-source analysis of Hormuz geography, traffic patterns, and energy infrastructure (EIA, Strauss Center, IMO TSS documentation) and extends it through analytic inference to develop the structural requirements of a durable post-crisis architecture.

1.1 The End-State Problem

The post-crisis architecture must simultaneously achieve three objectives that pull against each other:

- Deterrence without overpresence: permanent two-CSG Gulf presence degrades Indo-Pacific readiness. The architecture must deter reclosure without maintaining a crisis-level footprint indefinitely.
- Partner ownership without premature U.S. withdrawal: GCC partners must absorb operational majority over time, but early drawdown before partner capacity matures creates a gap Iran will exploit.
- Flexibility without ambiguity: preserve coercive options (Posture 3 branches) without signaling imminent territorial action, which fractures the coalition and accelerates Iranian escalation.

DOCUMENTED STRUCTURAL CONSTRAINT [HIGH CONFIDENCE]	*Combined bypass pipeline capacity (Saudi East-West pipeline, UAE Habshan-Fujairah, Iran Goreh-Jask) covers less than 15% of normal Hormuz flow. No LNG bypass exists. These figures are documented in EIA and IMO open-source data and are not scenario-conditioned. This constraint holds on any planning horizon under five years.*

1.2 Permanent MCM Basing Architecture

ASSESSMENT [MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]: Fujairah (UAE, Gulf of Oman side) is the optimal permanent MCM basing location. It is accessible during active strait closure; the UAE political relationship includes concrete deliverables sustaining basing access; and Gulf of Oman access allows clearance operations to begin outside the contested zone, reducing force-protection requirements. A permanent MCM squadron at Fujairah combined with forward-deployed MCM assets at Bahrain provides continuous coverage. This is an analytic recommendation based on documented geographic and political factors, not a reflection of any current U.S. planning posture.

1.3 Partner-Led Maritime Security Architecture Transition

The long-term objective is a Gulf maritime security framework with majority GCC operational ownership and U.S. forces in overwatch and deterrent roles. The CMF framework is the institutional vehicle.

IMPLEMENTATION FRICTION	*The hardest element of this transition is pace, not direction. Saudi Arabia and UAE have credible surface combatant capacity, but transitioning escort and MCM operational lead to GCC navies within 3–5 years requires sustained U.S. training investment, equipment transfer, and political will on both sides that is not guaranteed. The 3–5 year timeline is an analytic target, not a prediction. The transition remains analytically plausible because GCC governments have demonstrated consistent interest in expanding defense sovereignty, and U.S. capacity constraints make partner operational absorption a structural necessity rather than an option. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]*

- Saudi Arabia and UAE have credible surface combatant capacity to absorb patrol and escort functions over a 3–5 year horizon with U.S. training and equipment investment. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE]
- A GCC-led maritime security command with U.S. 5th Fleet in rapid-reinforcement role is the target architecture for years 3–5. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]
- CMF institutionalization as the primary operational framework removes the political liability of a permanent U.S.-command structure without removing U.S. deterrent capacity. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

1.4 Reconstitution Trigger Framework

The normalized posture requires explicit reconstitution triggers embedded as defined thresholds in formal posture review mechanisms. Note: all triggers are labeled with confidence terms consistent with the lexicon above.

Condition	Indicator	Posture Implication
Mine tempo exceeds MCM clearance capacity	TSS clearance falls behind Iranian mine deployment rate; tanker incidents resume during escort periods	Escalate to Posture 3 preparation; Kharg contingency moves from branch to active planning [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]
Strike on partner naval infrastructure	Iranian ballistic missile strike degrades 5th Fleet (Bahrain) or AFCENT (Al Udeid) operational capacity	Activate full missile defense; Article 51 response authorization; coalition Article-5-equivalent consultation [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]
Back-channel failure at 60 days	Oman/Swiss channels produce no Iranian movement; no negotiating signal within 60 days	Shift to coercive signaling; Kharg blockade threat as next coercive instrument before territorial action [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]
Coalition fragmentation	Qatar or UAE signals intent to reduce cooperation; GCC political tolerance visibly eroding	Accelerate bilateral deliverables: UAE island diplomacy; Saudi treaty. Do not allow fragmentation to cascade. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]
Iranian nuclear reconstitution	IAEA or intelligence indicators of accelerated enrichment beyond current baseline	Raise strategic cost calculus; coordinate Israel parallel track; consider Posture 3 coercive signaling [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]
Houthi/Bab el-Mandeb activation at scale	Simultaneous Houthi disruption reaching 40%+ of normal Red Sea commercial traffic	Activate Jordan Red Sea corridor; redirect UK/France CMF assets; dual-chokepoint operational planning triggered [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]
Mineral Framework	Verified resumption of China or	Immediate Tier 1 access suspension; 30-day

Condition	Indicator	Posture Implication
snap-back trigger	Russia IRGC-linked oil/minerals trade exceeding defined threshold; structural snap-back available but politically scenario-conditioned	cure period; if unremediated: full secondary sanctions posture re-engagement [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED — see Confidence Lexicon]

PART II: U.S.-ISRAEL COORDINATION PARAMETERS

Israel is the most capable military actor in the region with the most direct national interest in degrading Iranian military capacity. The GCC coalition constraint on public Israeli participation is documented in open-source political reporting and analysis; the parallel-track architecture is an analytic inference from that constraint.

2.1 What Israel Contributes [MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE, DOCUMENTED OPEN-SOURCE BASIS]

- Air superiority and long-range strike: F-35I stealth strike capability against Iranian nuclear and naval infrastructure; demonstrated strike capability in prior operations; coverage the U.S. would otherwise need to supply unilaterally.
- Intelligence architecture: Assessed as the most developed IRGC-targeting SIGINT/HUMINT of any regional actor based on open-source reporting and inference from demonstrated operational outcomes.
- Missile defense integration: Arrow-3 and David's Sling provide upper-tier ballistic missile defense complementing U.S. Patriot/THAAD.
- Deterrence signaling: Israeli willingness to strike Iranian nuclear infrastructure constrains Iranian escalation calculus independently of U.S. posture. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

2.2 Parallel Track Architecture [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

GCC partners cannot publicly coordinate with Israel — a binding political constraint documented in open-source political analysis of GCC domestic politics and foreign policy. The U.S. role is de-confliction at the U.S. level.

KEY REQUIREMENT	*Pre-agreed escalation de-confliction protocols between the U.S. and Israel are the minimum structural requirement. GCC partners need assurance that Israeli unilateral operations will not trigger Iranian retaliation on GCC territory without warning. This assurance requires operational coordination, not merely political communication. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]*

- Track 1 — GCC Coalition Track: Bahrain, Qatar, UAE, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Oman, UK, France, Japan/South Korea, India. No visible Israeli participation.
- Track 2 — U.S.-Israel Bilateral Track: Direct operational coordination, intelligence sharing, missile defense integration, strike de-confliction. Outputs incorporated into U.S. operational planning without attribution.

2.3 Saudi-Israel Normalization as a Strategic Variable [LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Documented open-source reporting indicates the Saudi-U.S. defense treaty negotiation and Saudi-Israeli normalization track were linked prior to October 2023. Whether that linkage remains operative in 2026 is analytically inferred from the structural logic of Saudi negotiating objectives, not from current confirmed reporting. [LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE — scenario-conditioned on Saudi political dynamics that are not directly observable from open sources.]

PART III: PARTNER-BY-PARTNER COORDINATION ARCHITECTURE

The following matrix is derived by analytic inference from documented national interests, historical behavior patterns, and open-source reporting on partner defense relationships. Partner behavior projections are SCENARIO-CONDITIONED and ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, not predictions.

Partner	Military Contribution	Core Interest	U.S. Offer	Sustaining Mechanism
Bahrain	5th Fleet HQ; CMF (38 nations); maritime escort command	Regime security vs. Iranian-backed internal opposition	Hardened NSA Bahrain air defense; formal defense commitment; arms sales	U.S. presence is regime deterrence — structurally aligned, low-maintenance
Qatar	Al Udeid (largest U.S. air base in region); AFCENT; ISR; SOF	LNG export continuity (100% Hormuz-dependent); security vs. Iran strike	Bilateral defense treaty (MNNA); Patriot/THAAD at Al Udeid; visible base hardening	Shared Hormuz dependency; hardening investment is the political signal
UAE	Al Dhafra (F-35/strike); Fujairah MCM hub outside strait; THAAD depth	Abu Musa/Tunb sovereignty return; F-35 access; technology transfer	Active diplomatic support for island sovereignty claim; expedited F-35/THAAD	UAE island claim is a concrete U.S. deliverable not yet deployed — execute it
Saudi Arabia	3.5–4.5M bpd spare capacity; PSAB/KKMC basing; AWACS	U.S. bilateral defense treaty; civilian nuclear rights; normalization support	Defense treaty framework; F-15/Patriot/THAAD; civilian nuclear engagement	Spare capacity and treaty are mutually contingent — neither acts without the other
Oman	Musandam Peninsula surveillance/patrol staging; U.S.-Iran back-channel	Preserve neutrality and Iran trade relationship	Respect public neutrality; private ISR/patrol staging; no coalition demands	Back-channel to Iran worth more than any military contribution — do not pressure
Kuwait	Camp Arifjan logistics; prepositioned equipment; reinforcement	Security guarantee vs. Iraqi instability and Iranian pressure	Ground presence; bilateral defense cooperation; preposition rights	1990 institutional memory makes U.S. guarantee foundational — low-maintenance

Partner	Military Contribution	Core Interest	U.S. Offer	Sustaining Mechanism
	staging			
Jordan	Air corridor; SOF staging; intelligence; Red Sea–Hormuz dual-chokepoint link	Aid continuity; F-16 upgrades; West Bank stability	Aid; equipment; Palestinian issue engagement	Most reliably consistent regional partner — do not neglect during Gulf focus
Israel	Most capable regional air force; IRGC SIGINT/HUMINT; Arrow/David's Sling	Freedom of action vs. Iran; missile defense integration; resupply	Intelligence sharing; missile defense integration; diplomatic cover; resupply	Parallel track — U.S. de-confliction keeps Israel outside visible GCC coalition
UK	CMF naval escort; JLSU Bahrain; Five Eyes intelligence	Partner status not subordinate role; U.S. intelligence access	Planning participation; operational credit; full intelligence sharing	Institutionally embedded; bounded, credited contributions
France	CMF escort; independent Iran diplomatic channel; EU legitimacy	Seat at diplomatic resolution table; political parity	Lead role in EU coordination; defined diplomatic track	France sustains military contribution only if it sees political return — provide it
Japan / S. Korea	Financial burden-sharing; escort logistics; MCM support (constitutional limits)	Supply continuity (84% Hormuz crude is Asian); Indo-Pacific assurance	Priority SPR volumes; escort for flagged tankers; Indo-Pacific commitment signals	Earnest Will financial model — reduces U.S. cost, keeps partners invested
India	Independent naval capacity; Chabahar access; parallel partner	Strategic autonomy; supply security; will not subordinate Iran ties	Bilateral route-safety/MCM data sharing; QUAD engagement; no public coalition ask	Bilateral coordination without coalition membership — parallel beneficiary

3.1 Tier 1: Indispensable Partners

Bahrain

Documented: 5th Fleet headquarters at NSA Bahrain; CMF structure with 38 partner nations (U.S. DoD open-source). Inferred: Bahraini government interest in sustaining U.S. presence as regime deterrence against Iranian-backed internal opposition is analytically inferred from documented reporting on Bahraini domestic politics and the 2011 unrest period. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Qatar

Documented: Al Udeid Air Base as AFCENT headquarters; Iranian ballistic missile strike on Al Udeid June 2025 (Tier 2 open-source reporting). Inferred: Qatar's LNG-transit dependency creating structural alignment with Hormuz security is documented in EIA data; the political conclusion that this makes Qatar an active co-investor in MCM operations rather than merely a passive host is analytically inferred. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

IMPLEMENTATION FRICTION	*Qatar's independent Iran diplomatic and trade relationship is the primary friction point in this partner relationship. Qatar will not publicly condemn Iran or join a formally anti-Iran coalition without threatening domestic political stability and its Iran economic ties. Managing this constraint requires deliberate restraint on U.S. demands — specifically, not requiring Qatar to make public anti-Iran postures as a condition of operational cooperation. The analytic case for Qatar's cooperation rests on shared LNG-transit interests, not shared Iran policy. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, with acknowledged political tolerance uncertainty at 6–12 months]*

UAE

Documented: Al Dhafra Air Base; Fujairah port facilities on Gulf of Oman; UAE sovereignty claim over Abu Musa and Tunbs; China's December 2025 backing of UAE claim (GlobalSecurity.org/RFE-RL Tier 2). Inferred: U.S. active diplomatic support for UAE island claim as a tradeable deliverable for Fujairah/Al Dhafra access is analytically inferred from the documented diplomatic landscape. The exchange has not been executed and its political feasibility depends on factors not fully visible from open sources. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on availability of the lever; LOWER CONFIDENCE on specific exchange terms]

Saudi Arabia

Documented: Saudi spare capacity assessed at 3.5–4.5 million bpd (EIA); defense treaty negotiation history documented in open-source reporting. The treaty has not been concluded. Inferred: the conditionality between spare capacity deployment and treaty progress is an analytic inference from Saudi negotiating behavior, not a confirmed statement of Saudi policy.

IMPLEMENTATION FRICTION	*The Saudi-U.S. defense treaty is the single hardest element in the Tier 1 partner architecture. Finalizing a treaty framework in the 3–12 month window is analytically plausible given crisis forcing-function logic, but it requires: sustained U.S. political commitment across potential administration changes; Saudi willingness to accept U.S. nonproliferation conditions on civilian nuclear program; and progress on Israeli normalization that may be blocked by regional politics. If the treaty stalls, the fallback is an ad hoc spare capacity arrangement using economic incentives — operationally viable for 3–12 months while negotiation continues, but less durable. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on direction; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on timeline]*

3.2 Tier 2: Significant Contributors

Oman

Documented: Oman's role as U.S.-Iran back-channel host is documented in open-source accounts of nuclear negotiations and prior crisis de-escalation. Musandam Peninsula geography is documented. Inferred: Oman's willingness to host ISR/patrol staging at a level it can defend domestically as non-combat is an inference from Oman's historical behavior. The back-channel's operational availability in March 2026 is scenario-conditioned on current Omani-Iranian diplomatic relations. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on availability; the specific political tolerance ceiling is a key unknown]

Kuwait and Jordan

Documented: Camp Arifjan ground logistics infrastructure (DoD open-source). Jordan's consistent bilateral defense cooperation with the U.S. is well-documented in open-source

reporting. Inferred: Kuwait's 1990 institutional memory as a sustaining mechanism for U.S. guarantee acceptance, and Jordan's Red Sea access relevance to a dual-chokepoint scenario, are analytically inferred from documented history and geographic analysis. [MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE on historical pattern; MODERATE CONFIDENCE on forward projection]

3.3 Tier 3: Strategic Partners with Functional Roles

United Kingdom and France

Documented: UK JLSU Bahrain presence; CMF participation (DoD open-source). France's independent Iran diplomatic relationship is documented in open-source foreign policy reporting. Inferred: France's military contribution being contingent on a defined diplomatic role is inferred from observed French behavior in prior multilateral frameworks, not from current stated French policy on a Hormuz crisis. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Japan, South Korea, and India

Documented: Japan and South Korea's Hormuz crude dependency is documented in EIA data. Earnest Will financial burden-sharing model is documented historically. India's Chabahar Port development and strategic autonomy doctrine are well-documented — including India's $85M investment in the Shahid Beheshti terminal operationalized in 2024, which creates a concrete Indian economic stake in Iranian economic stability that is in some tension with deep IRGC economic rollback. India is not merely maintaining abstract strategic autonomy; it has specific infrastructure interests in a functioning Iranian port that would be disrupted by comprehensive IRGC economic dismantlement. This tension does not prevent bilateral MCM data-sharing or parallel operational coordination, but it means India's cooperation on IRGC-specific pressure tracks is more constrained than on transit security tracks. Inferred: the specific financial contribution modalities and bilateral MCM data-sharing arrangements are analytic projections from documented precedent and stated policy positions. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on direction; specific terms are scenario-conditioned; Chabahar tension is ANALYTICALLY INFERRED as a constraint on IRGC-pressure cooperation specifically]

PART IV: INTEGRATED POSTURE, PARTNER, AND KPI TIMELINE

The following framework integrates U.S. posture objectives, partner activation requirements, and quantified scenario benchmarks across four time horizons.

Period	U.S. Objective	Primary Posture	Key Partner Actions	Desired End-State	Illustrative KPI
0–30 days	Restore confidence; prevent escalation spiral	Surge maritime-air defense; DFC insurance; SPR release	Qatar/Bahrain: accept hardening teams. Saudi Arabia: commit spare capacity schedule. Japan/S. Korea: fund DFC insurance backstop.	Partial commercial re-opening; insurance market stabilization	~50% transit volume; 0 escort incidents 14 consecutive days [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]

Period	U.S. Objective	Primary Posture	Key Partner Actions	Desired End-State	Illustrative KPI
30–90 days	Stabilize flows; reassure markets	Distributed regional security; persistent escort and MCM	UAE: activate Fujairah MCM/logistics. Oman: open Iran back-channel. France: EU diplomatic track. UK: CMF escort rotation.	Predictable escort/MCM regime; tanker confidence partially restored	~70% transit volume; insurance below $500K/voyage; Oman channel active [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]
3–12 months	Prevent reclosure; sustain deterrence; open diplomatic track	Hardened distributed campaign; coalition burden-sharing; Hormuz Conference convened	Saudi: defense treaty finalized. Jordan: SOF corridor active. Israel: de-confliction protocols in force. India: MCM data-sharing active. China: Track 1 back-channel engaged.	Resilient allied transit; diplomatic resolution track open with Iran observer status	~85% transit; 1 CSG rotational; Iran observer at Conference; 30 attack-free days [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]
1–5 years	Avoid permanent crisis footing; deter without overextension	Normalized posture; reduced footprint; GCC-led MCM; Gulf Maritime Forum active; Mineral Framework Tier 1 operational	GCC: majority MCM/escort ownership. Fujairah permanent MCM basing. CMF institutionalized. Iran as Forum observer. China: Tier 1 mineral access conditional on verified IRGC decoupling.	Deterrence without permanent U.S. crisis-level overpresence; self-enforcing regional architecture	~95%+ transit; footprint below 20% surge peak; 12 attack-free months; IAEA compliance; IRGC revenue share below 20% [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

4.1 Quantified KPI and Exit Threshold Framework

The following thresholds are illustrative analytic posture-review benchmarks for scenario evaluation, not operational commitments, forecasts, or guaranteed outcomes. All figures are scenario-conditioned on the stated premises holding. Actual transit volume restoration, attack-

free day counts, and partner political tolerance outcomes will depend on factors not fully visible from open-source analysis. Thresholds are labeled [SC] for scenario-conditioned and confidence levels are noted where the underlying inference is particularly sensitive to unresolved variables.

Horizon	Transit Volume	Military Threshold	Diplomatic Threshold	Exit / Normalization Condition
0–30 days	≈50% baseline [SC]	0 escort incidents 14 consecutive days; MCM clears primary TSS lanes [SC]	Oman back-channel open; DFC insurance backstop active [SC]	N/A — surge phase; no exit
30–90 days	≈70% baseline [SC]	War-risk premiums below $500K/voyage; 21 attack-free days [SC]	Iran back-channel active; France EU track open; Hormuz Conference proposed publicly [SC]	Reduction from 2 CSG to 1.5 CSG equivalent authorized if thresholds met [SC]
3–12 months	≈85% baseline [SC, MOD CONF]	30 consecutive attack-free days; CSG surge reduced to single rotational [SC]	Iran observer status at Conference; provisional transit agreement signed; partial sanctions relief tied to compliance [SC]	Coalition transitions to CMF co-led; GCC navies absorbing 40%+ of escort ops [SC, MOD CONF]
1–5 years	≈95%+ baseline [SC, LOW-MOD CONF]	12 consecutive attack-free months; footprint below 20% surge peak [SC, LOW-MOD CONF]	Gulf Maritime Forum operational; IAEA compliance; IRGC revenue below 20% [SC, LOW CONF]	Full normalization; GCC-led architecture primary; U.S. in overwatch/deterrent role [SC, LOW CONF]

Table notation: [SC] = Scenario-Conditioned. [MOD CONF] = Moderate Confidence. [LOW-MOD CONF] = Low-Moderate Confidence. [LOW CONF] = Low Confidence. All figures are analytic scenario benchmarks, not predictions.

PART V: DIPLOMATIC RESOLUTION FRAMEWORK

The following diplomatic sequencing is an analytic model derived from documented precedent (OSCE architecture, JCPOA structure, Operation Earnest Will back-channel history) and scenario inference. It is not a description of current diplomatic activity. Documented open-source reporting as of March 2026 does not confirm that any of these tracks are currently operational.

CORE DIPLOMATIC LOGIC [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]	*Military protection creates the space for diplomacy. Diplomacy creates the framework for normalization. Normalization creates the conditions for sustainable deterrence without permanent overpresence. Iran is conditionally included — with defined compliance requirements at each stage — because sustainable regional stability requires Iranian stakeholdership, not Iranian exclusion. The off-ramp must be visible and credible or Iranian moderates have no political basis on which to argue for*

	compliance. These are inferences from historical precedent in comparable crisis-to-normalization transitions, not predictions about Iranian political behavior.

Track	Forum / Mechanism	Participants	Agenda	Conditionality
Track 1: Back-channel (0–90 days)	Oman channel; Swiss interests section; Chinese intermediary	U.S., Iran (via Oman/Swiss); China as indirect pressure channel	No Kharg seizure vs. halt to vessel attacks; humanitarian passage for neutral-flagged tankers	Iran halts new mine-laying for 30 days in exchange for back-channel opening; no public announcement
Track 2: Hormuz Transit Conference (3–6 months)	UN-facilitated multilateral forum; Oman or Switzerland as host neutral	U.S., GCC, EU (France lead), China, India, Japan/S. Korea; Iran as observer initially	UNCLOS Article 38 codification; UN observers on Abu Musa/Tunbs; provisional de-mining schedule; phased sanctions relief framework	Iran observer status: 30 consecutive attack-free days + IAEA access restoration
Track 3: Gulf Maritime Forum (12–36 months)	Permanent multilateral security forum; OSCE-modeled; CMF institutional successor	All Track 2 participants + Iran as full member post-compliance; Israel via indirect parallel track	Transparency obligations; joint MCM exercises; dispute resolution mechanism; bypass infrastructure investment coordination	Iranian full membership: 12 attack-free months + IAEA nuclear compliance + formal renunciation of unilateral closure authority
Track 4: Economic Integration (24–60 months)	U.S.-China bilateral framework; GCC mineral access program; Iran-conditional economic normalization	U.S., China, GCC leads (Saudi/UAE); Russia (long-horizon, low-confidence); Iran contingent on compliance	GCC mineral access for compliant great powers; Saudi bypass expansion; UAE African lithium stakes; China-Iran trade normalization conditional on open transit; sanctions relief tiers tied to verified compliance	Economic normalization in proportion to verified compliance; each milestone unlocks defined relief tranche, reversible on violation

5.1 Back-Channel Activation (Track 1, 0–90 Days)

Documented precedent: Oman's back-channel role in U.S.-Iran communications is documented in open-source accounts of nuclear negotiations and the 2013 preliminary talks. Its current availability in the context of an active IRGC closure posture is scenario-conditioned on Omani-Iranian diplomatic conditions in March 2026 that are not directly observable from open sources — back-channel availability should not be assumed as a given but treated as a key unknown requiring early confirmation. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on historical availability; SCENARIO-CONDITIONED on current status]

Inferred: The specific opening proposition — no Kharg seizure assurance in exchange for a 30-day mine-laying halt — is an analytic construct derived from the documented logic of crisis back-channel openings, not a current U.S. stated position. This framing should be understood

as a process-opening mechanism, not a clean bilateral transaction. The risk of framing it as a transaction is that it signals U.S. preference ordering — revealing that the U.S. values back-channel engagement more than Iran does — which could reduce Iranian willingness to negotiate. The correct framing is that the back-channel opens a process from which both parties can explore whether a larger arrangement is available, without committing either side to specific terms at the outset. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

The Chinese intermediary track is available in principle based on documented Chinese economic exposure to Hormuz disruption and the December 2025 UAE island statement, but whether China would exercise this role in March 2026 conditions is a scenario-conditioned variable. [LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

5.2 Hormuz Transit Conference (Track 2, 3–6 Months)

The Conference model draws on documented precedent from the OSCE Helsinki process and UNCLOS multilateral codification processes. Its applicability to the Hormuz crisis context is analytically inferred. Iran's observer-status pathway is modeled on the documented logic of confidence-building measure frameworks used in comparable contexts. The specific conditionality terms — 30 attack-free days, IAEA access restoration — are analytic threshold proposals, not negotiated positions. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on framework; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Iranian participation willingness]

5.3 Gulf Maritime Forum (Track 3, 12–36 Months)

The Gulf Maritime Forum draws on the OSCE confidence-building architecture as an institutional design reference, not as a direct historical precedent. The analogy has structural limits that must be stated explicitly. Helsinki succeeded because participating states had already accepted the territorial and political status quo being codified — the process formalized an existing geopolitical reality rather than requiring states to renounce actively-pursued claims. The Forum pathway faces three structural disanalogies with that model: Iran is not positioned to accept the full normative premises of a UNCLOS-derived transit regime on current terms, given that it is not a party to UNCLOS and contests the TSS's binding character under its national law; observer status under active U.S. and allied sanctions with concurrent legal-posture rejection has no close multilateral precedent; and constructing multilateral diplomatic infrastructure of this complexity from a standing start during an active crisis is substantially more compressed than any comparable historical preparatory timeline. The Forum's near-term political feasibility should therefore be understood through the lens of the 1987–88 Gulf naval de-confliction arrangements and the Iran-Iraq ceasefire monitoring architecture — modest confidence-building and crisis-management mechanisms — rather than the full Helsinki process. The Forum pathway is constrained by a real legal-political gap: Iran is not positioned to accept the full normative premises of a UNCLOS-derived transit regime on current terms, so observer status should be understood as a crisis-management and confidence-building mechanism first, not as evidence of prior legal convergence. The Forum's institutional design logic remains sound; its near-term political feasibility depends on Iranian domestic conditions not directly observable from open sources. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Iranian participation willingness]

Iranian full membership conditionality — 12 attack-free months, verified IAEA nuclear compliance, formal renunciation of unilateral closure authority — is designed to be achievable by a government that has made a genuine political decision to normalize, and unachievable by

one using negotiations as cover for continued offensive operations. These conditions are demanding precisely because the Forum's value depends on Iranian compliance being genuine rather than performative.

5.4 Economic Integration (Track 4, 24–60 Months)

The economic integration mechanisms build on documented Saudi Vision 2030 mining initiative investments and UAE overseas mineral acquisition activity (Manara, IRH). The specific conditional linkages between those investments and compliance incentives for Iran and China are analytically inferred. The conditionality architecture draws on documented JCPOA sanctions-relief structure as a design precedent, modified to correct the reversibility ambiguity that undermined the original structure. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on structural logic; implementation feasibility is LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

PART VI: ALTERNATIVE BRANCH SCENARIOS

The following scenarios model the architecture's response under varying premise conditions. All three scenarios are SCENARIO-CONDITIONED. Confidence labels reflect the assessed probability of each scenario's trigger conditions materializing, not the quality of the response logic.

Scenario	Trigger Conditions	Primary Risk	U.S. Response Adjustment	Confidence
OPTIMISTIC: Rapid diplomatic buy-in (< 6 months)	China intervenes diplomatically; Iran accepts partial reopening within 60 days; Oman channel productive	Premature drawdown before GCC partner capacity matures; Iran exploiting perceived U.S. eagerness to exit	Maintain MCM and 1 CSG for 12 months beyond diplomatic agreement. Posture enforces agreement — do not trade posture for agreement.	LOW — requires Iranian political willingness not evidenced in current behavior
BASELINE: Gradual normalization (12–24 months)	Diplomatic progress uneven; Iran accepts partial measures; GCC coalition holds with active management	Coalition fatigue at 9–12 months; Qatar/UAE political tolerance under pressure; Saudi treaty stalls	Accelerate bilateral deliverables before tolerance erodes. Activate Japan/South Korea financial contributions. Saudi treaty fallback: ad hoc capacity arrangement with economic incentives while negotiation continues.	MODERATE — consistent with historical Iranian behavior and GCC partner tolerance patterns
PESSIMISTIC: Prolonged proxy conflict (24–60 months)	Iran rejects all diplomatic tracks; mine tempo sustained; Houthi and PMF simultaneously activated	Strategic drag on Indo-Pacific posture; coalition fragmentation; Chinese economic retaliation; Iranian nuclear reconstitution acceleration	Execute Posture 3 Kharg coercive signaling (not seizure). Invoke Earnest Will financial model at maximum scale. Re-engage China directly on shared economic costs.	LOW-MODERATE — multi-front simultaneous activation requires Iranian capability and political will

Scenario	Trigger Conditions	Primary Risk	U.S. Response Adjustment	Confidence
				assessed as currently stretched

6.1 Scenario Sensitivity Analysis

Three variables drive the divergence between baseline and pessimistic outcomes:

- Chinese diplomatic intervention timing: Scenario-conditioned on China's internal cost calculus. Key observable indicator: Chinese statements on strait transit rights in UN forums at 30–45 days. [LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on Chinese intervention willingness]
- Saudi treaty negotiation pace: Scenario-conditioned on sustained U.S. political commitment and Saudi willingness to accept nonproliferation conditions. Saudi treaty fallback (ad hoc spare capacity arrangement with economic incentives) is analytically available but less durable. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on fallback; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on treaty timeline]
- Iranian escalation threshold: The most consequential and least answerable variable. Monitor mine-laying tempo as operational commitment indicator; back-channel responsiveness as political intent indicator. These are the two best available open-source proxies for an unresolvable uncertainty. [LOW CONFIDENCE — explicitly acknowledged]

PART VII: PROXY AND MULTI-FRONT RISK ARCHITECTURE

The following threat vectors are assessed from documented open-source reporting on Iranian proxy network capabilities and 2024–25 activation patterns, extended by analytic inference to the 2026 crisis scenario. Source-tier and confidence labels are included in the table.

Threat Vector	Current Status (March 2026) [Source Tier]	Trigger Threshold	Response Mechanism
Houthi / Bab el-Mandeb	Active; demonstrated dual-chokepoint capability 2024–25; tempo in March 2026 assessed from open-source reporting [TIER 2 — scenario-conditioned]	Simultaneous Bab el-Mandeb commercial disruption reaching ~40% of normal Red Sea traffic	Activate Jordan Red Sea corridor; redirect UK/France CMF assets; Earnest Will financial model for Red Sea escort; bilateral India Red Sea routing coordination [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]
PMF / Iraq proxy escalation	Persistent low-level attacks on U.S. Iraq positions documented in open-source reporting; tempo	PMF attacks degrading U.S. logistics or command infrastructure affecting Gulf operational tempo	Defensive force protection; Iraqi government pressure for PMF restraint; do not allow Iraq/Syria force protection to divert assets from primary Hormuz mission

Threat Vector	Current Status (March 2026) [Source Tier]	Trigger Threshold	Response Mechanism
	increase during Gulf crisis is analytically inferred [TIER 2/INFERRED]		[ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]
Hezbollah / Lebanon front	Deterred post-2024; residual capability retained; activation risk during Iran-U.S. conflict is analytically inferred [TIER 2/INFERRED]	Hezbollah missile activation against Israeli or U.S. regional assets coinciding with Hormuz crisis	Israel-U.S. parallel track handles Hezbollah response; Gulf posture does not divert to Lebanon; de-confliction ensures no ISR/strike asset competition [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]
Chinese economic retaliation	Rare earth export restrictions assessed as more likely than naval intervention; basis is structural incentive analysis [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]	Formal rare earth export restriction targeting U.S. defense industrial base; active diplomatic campaign to fracture GCC coalition	Activate U.S.-China bilateral economic framework; engage China on shared oil price impact; offer China-specific track at Hormuz Conference; accelerate bilateral GCC deliverables if Chinese pressure appears to influence coalition behavior [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]
Mineral Framework defection	Risk is scenario-conditioned on Tier 1 access being granted; no documented baseline [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]	Verified resumption of IRGC-linked trade exceeding $500M annual volume by state or state-affiliated entity	Immediate Tier 1 access suspension; 30-day cure period; if unremediated: full snap-back to secondary sanctions posture. Note: snap-back political activation is scenario-conditioned on coalition consensus. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]

7.1 Dual-Chokepoint Scenario: Hormuz and Bab el-Mandeb

Documented: Houthi Bab el-Mandeb disruption in 2024–25 is well-documented in open-source shipping and commercial reporting. The dual-chokepoint operational logic — simultaneous activation to compound global freight disruption — is documented in open-source analysis of Houthi and IRGC strategic communications. Inferred: whether Iran would activate the dual-chokepoint scenario in a 2026 Hormuz crisis is scenario-conditioned on Iranian escalation calculus that is not directly observable. [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED from documented 2024–25 pattern, MODERATE CONFIDENCE on capability; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on intent in this scenario]

7.2 Chinese Economic Retaliation

ASSESSMENT [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]: Chinese economic retaliation is assessed as more likely than Chinese naval intervention based on structural analysis of Chinese naval basing limitations in the Gulf and documented Chinese economic statecraft behavior in prior coercive contexts (rare earth restrictions 2010, 2023). This is an analytic inference from documented patterns, not a prediction of Chinese behavior in this specific scenario.

PART VIII: CONDITIONAL GREAT-POWER MINERAL TRADE FRAMEWORK

This section presents the conditional great-power mineral trade framework as a Track 4 economic statecraft instrument. It is the most analytically innovative and most contestable element of this document. The framework is assessed as a conditional strategic inducement mechanism with defined verification limits — not independently decisive, not guaranteed to produce durable IRGC decoupling at the entity level, but analytically sound as a cost-imposition and bargaining leverage mechanism when synchronized with financial-statecraft companion instruments.

8.1 Strategic Logic [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]

Documented: Saudi Vision 2030 mining initiative ($110B scale); UAE Manara Minerals and IRH overseas acquisition strategy in African lithium and copper; China's dominant role in rare earth processing; China's status as Iran's largest crude customer; China's role as major GCC hydrocarbon importer — all documented in open-source financial and energy reporting.

Inferred: the proposition that GCC critical mineral access creates sufficient economic leverage to incentivize China-IRGC decoupling is an analytic inference from the documented structure of these economic relationships. The mechanism is conditional, not independently decisive, and its potency is back-loaded rather than immediate. Saudi Arabia's critical mineral output — copper concentrate, rare earth oxide, lithium carbonate — is not yet at commercial scale on timelines that would make Chinese supply chain integration meaningfully coercive within the 1–5 year planning horizon. UAE overseas stakes are minority positions in projects with their own development cycles. The self-interest enforcement mechanism is therefore better characterized as follows: on the near-term horizon, its value is primarily as an incremental signaling and bargaining leverage instrument, demonstrating that a defined economic cost to defection exists and will grow; on the 5–10 year horizon, as GCC mineral access becomes operationally embedded in Chinese supply chains, the switching-cost dynamic matures into a more substantial compliance driver. This temporal realism does not undermine the framework — it correctly scopes its role within a synchronized package of instruments.

ENFORCEMENT LOGIC [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]	*The primary enforcement mechanism is not external monitoring but Chinese self-interest in maintaining access: GCC mineral access, once operationally embedded in Chinese supply chains, creates economic costs to losing it that grow over time. External monitoring via OFAC/Treasury and INFRA-01 OSINT predicates supplements this self-reinforcing dynamic but cannot substitute for it. The verification gap between Chinese government acceptance of conditionality and actual enforcement against Chinese state-affiliated entities is a real and acknowledged limit of this framework.*

8.2 China Track [MODERATE CONFIDENCE]

Documented: China-Iran crude oil trade volume; China's rare earth processing dominance; Chinese state investment in Iranian mining infrastructure — documented in open-source energy and financial reporting. China's December 2025 UAE island sovereignty backing is documented (GlobalSecurity.org/RFE-RL).

IMPLEMENTATION FRICTION	*The verification gap is the hardest element of the China track. Chinese state and state-affiliated entities conduct IRGC-linked oil trade through opaque corporate structures, flag-hopped shadow fleets, and UAE/Malaysian blending terminals. Full verification of cessation requires not just OFAC monitoring but active Chinese government enforcement against entities that the Chinese government may not fully control or may have political reasons to protect. Annual compliance audits mitigate but do not eliminate this gap. The framework's credibility rests on self-interest in maintaining access, not on the achievability of complete verification. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on framework logic; LOWER CONFIDENCE on entity-level compliance achievability]*

Tier	Actor	GCC Mineral Access Offered	Entry Condition	Snap-Back Trigger
Tier 1 Entry	China	Preferred partner status in Saudi copper/rare earth development (Vision 2030 mining pillar); UAE African lithium JV participation via Manara/IRH framework	Verified cessation of direct IRGC-entity oil/minerals procurement for 90 consecutive days; OFAC/Treasury monitoring via INFRA-01 predicates; Chinese government cooperation with entity-level compliance [MODERATE CONFIDENCE — see friction note]	Resumption of IRGC-linked trade by any Chinese state or state-affiliated entity exceeding $500M annual volume; verified within 60 days via OSINT/SIGINT [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]
Tier 1 Maintenance	China	Expanded access: Saudi lithium/phosphate; Jordanian phosphate; UAE copper processing partnerships; preferred pricing in GCC SWF co-investment rounds	Annual compliance audit (OFAC-led with GCC partner intelligence contribution); China demonstrates active enforcement against sanctioned Iranian entities within its jurisdiction [MODERATE CONFIDENCE — enforcement scope limited, see Section 8.2]	Any verified IRGC-linked procurement resumption; failure to cooperate with annual audit; Chinese diplomatic facilitation of Iranian sanctions evasion [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]
Tier 2 Conditional	Russia	Limited observer status in GCC mineral trade forums; conditional on Ukraine war resolution trajectory [LOW CONFIDENCE — long-horizon variable only]	Russia-IRGC relationship is primarily military-operational (drone/missile supply chains for Ukraine), not mineral-economic. Full Tier 1 conditions are not achievable on current timeline. Tier 2 is a 5–10 year placeholder contingent on Ukraine war resolution. [LOW CONFIDENCE]	Tier 2 snap-back N/A on current timeline. Russia conditionality is not enforceable at Tier 1 scale until military supply relationship with IRGC is materially changed by Ukraine war resolution. [LOW CONFIDENCE]
Iran Civilian Track	Iranian non-IRGC institutions	Sanctions relief tranches tied to verified IRGC economic rollback; access to international	IRGC share of Iranian oil export revenue verifiably below 20%; IAEA full access restored; IRGC-linked shadow fleet ceased; Iranian	IRGC revenue share returns above 20%; IAEA access suspended; shadow fleet resumes. Civilian-sector relief tranches remain in place

Tier	Actor	GCC Mineral Access Offered	Entry Condition	Snap-Back Trigger
		capital markets for non-IRGC Iranian entities; humanitarian carve-outs maintained throughout all phases	government formally designates IRGC entities subject to domestic economic restructuring [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on measurability; see Section 8.4]	— snap-back applies to IRGC-specific sanctions only, not humanitarian provisions. [SCENARIO-CONDITIONED]

8.3 Russia Track [LOW CONFIDENCE — Long-Horizon Variable Only]

Russia's Iran relationship post-2022 is military-operational, not primarily mineral-economic. Documented: Russian receipt of Iranian Shahed-series drones and Fateh-110 ballistic missiles for Ukraine operations; Russian provision of S-400 systems and nuclear technology to Iran — documented in open-source defense reporting. Inferred: the assessment that this supply chain is driven by battlefield necessity and not amenable to mineral-economic incentives on near-term horizons is an analytic inference from the documented structure of the relationship.

ASSESSMENT [LOW CONFIDENCE]: The conditions under which Russia's Iran relationship becomes susceptible to GCC mineral trade incentives require Ukraine war resolution, post-war Russian economic reorientation toward supply chain diversification, and a GCC mineral offer of sufficient scale to compete with existing Russia-China mineral trade. None of these conditions are achievable on the 1–5 year planning horizon. Treating Russia symmetrically with China in this framework would be analytically incorrect. Russia's Tier 2 placeholder is documented as a long-horizon scenario signal, not an operable near-term mechanism.

8.4 Iranian Civilian Political Differentiation [MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE on legal logic; MODERATE CONFIDENCE on operational measurability]

The target of this framework is the IRGC economic network: Khatam al-Anbiya and its subsidiaries, Sepah Bank, shadow-fleet oil export operations, and IRGC-linked commercial entities documented in open-source OFAC designation lists and research by Transparency for Iran and UANI. The framework explicitly does not target: the Iranian civilian population, non-IRGC Iranian state institutions, humanitarian trade, or food and medicine imports. This distinction is analytically and legally necessary for sanctions design, but it should not be mistaken for a clean institutional boundary inside Iran's political economy, where IRGC penetration into nominally civilian sectors — through layered holding structures, nominee ownership, and politically-connected intermediaries in construction, telecommunications, petrochemicals, and logistics — remains extensive. A sanctions architecture achieving meaningful IRGC economic rollback will have some civilian economic impact through these interconnected ownership structures even when humanitarian carve-outs are rigorously maintained. The operative principle is therefore calibrated minimization of civilian spillover, not the claim that perfect separation is operationally achievable. Enforcement should be continuously recalibrated as entity-level mapping improves, rather than treated as a fixed architecture applied at the outset.

IMPLEMENTAT	*The hardest measurability problem in this framework is the IRGC revenue share*

ION FRICTION	*threshold. No open-source methodology presently appears capable of attributing IRGC versus non-IRGC oil-export revenue with the level of precision required for deterministic threshold enforcement. AIS-based vessel tracking identifies ship movements and infers cargo — it cannot attribute revenue to organizational principals within the Iranian state. OFAC designation lists identify IRGC-linked entities but cannot capture the full revenue flow through estimated 150+ sanctioned and unsanctioned front companies. Financial network analysis via Section 314(a) reaches correspondent banking relationships but not cash and barter flows bypassing the banking system. An unverifiable threshold risks functioning as a compliance theater mechanism: Iran and China perform the appearance of compliance while the verification architecture cannot confirm or deny it, making snap-back politically unusable because its activation becomes permanently contestable. The response to this risk is a composite proxy verification methodology rather than sole reliance on a revenue-attribution threshold. Observable proxies that collectively constitute a verifiable compliance signal include: verified AIS-based shadow fleet operational cessation; Khatam al-Anbiya absence from internationally contracted projects; Sepah Bank correspondent relationship severance from SWIFT; reduction in IRGC-affiliated entities in OFAC active-designation updates. Collectively, these indicators are more robust than any single revenue-share metric. The 20% threshold should be interpreted as an analytic review benchmark indicating materially declining IRGC penetration — not as a mechanically certifiable revenue-allocation standard. [MODERATE CONFIDENCE on threshold direction; LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE on precise measurement; composite proxy methodology materially improves but does not fully resolve verification limits]*

CIVILIAN PROTECTION COMMITMENT	*Humanitarian carve-outs — food, medicine, and non-sanctioned civilian trade — remain in force throughout all phases of this framework, including during snap-back activation. Snap-back applies to IRGC-specific economic sanctions only. Civilian-sector relief tranches are not reversible on snap-back. This is the legal and normative architecture that makes the framework internationally defensible under IHL principles and coalition-sustainable with GCC partners who maintain civilian trade relationships with Iran. Perfect IRGC-civilian separation is not operationally achievable given IRGC penetration of civilian sectors; the commitment is to rigorous calibration, ongoing enforcement review, and minimization of civilian spillover — not a claim of clean separation that the Iranian political economy does not permit.*

PART IX: FINAL ASSESSMENT

FINAL JUDGMENT [MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE — SCENARIO-CONDITIONED THROUGHOUT]	*The analysis indicates that the following architecture is the most structurally coherent under the stated premises: a phased military-to-diplomatic transition producing a self-enforcing regional security framework in which U.S. forces provide the deterrent ceiling; GCC partners provide the operational floor; a multilateral diplomatic architecture creates the institutional framework for normalization; and a conditional great-power mineral trade framework raises the cost of IRGC-linked trade for China while maintaining snap-back enforcement capacity. The goal is resilient allied transit and sustainable regional stability without permanent U.S. management burden. This architecture is designed to hold across administrations, coalition partners with divergent values, and Iranian governments with divergent political orientations, because it is grounded in structural interests, not political goodwill. All mechanisms are scenario-conditioned and assessed at the confidence levels documented*

throughout this paper.

Documented open-source basis: The foundational physical, legal, and economic facts (Hormuz traffic data, UNCLOS transit passage framework, Iranian mine inventory estimates, IRGC economic holdings, GCC partner defense infrastructure) are drawn from Tier 1 and Tier 2 sources cited in the reference section and are assessed at HIGH or MODERATE CONFIDENCE. The architecture built on those facts — diplomatic sequencing, partner behavior projections, KPI thresholds, mineral framework mechanisms — is ANALYTICALLY INFERRED or SCENARIO-CONDITIONED throughout, at confidence levels noted at point of use.

The principal risk factors that could force deviation from this architecture are: Iranian mine tempo exceeding MCM clearance capacity; coalition fragmentation before bilateral deliverables are executed; Chinese economic retaliation fracturing Asian partner financial contributions; dual-chokepoint activation; and Mineral Framework defection. Each has a defined response mechanism. None of the response mechanisms are guaranteed to succeed — they are analytic responses assessed as plausible under stated premises.

Success should be defined as: resilient allied transit at approximately 95% of baseline volume; U.S. military footprint at or below 20% of surge peak; a functioning Gulf Maritime Forum with Iranian observer status; verified IAEA nuclear compliance; and IRGC share of Iranian oil export revenue in a verifiably declining trajectory. These are demanding scenario-conditioned targets. Their achievability on a 5-year horizon depends on variables — Iranian escalation threshold, Chinese diplomatic intervention timing, Saudi treaty pace — that are not fully predictable from open-source analysis. The targets are analytically justified as the minimum conditions for sustainable deterrence without permanent overpresence.

This assessment should be read alongside companion financial-statecraft papers for statutory authorities, sanctions enforcement sequencing, and financial isolation architecture. The posture framework is strongest when maritime resilience, coalition management, diplomatic sequencing, Treasury-led financial pressure, and great-power mineral statecraft are synchronized as a single integrated campaign rather than parallel policy lanes.

SOURCES AND REFERENCE BASIS

Sources are organized by tier consistent with the analytic methodology note in the front matter. Tier 3 sources are used for contextual background only and do not carry Tier 1-certainty conclusions. The documented/modeled boundary convention applies: claims derived from these sources are labeled at point of use.

Companion Papers (WP-2026 Series):

- WP-2026-HORMUZ-01 — Regional Posture Assessment (foundational posture logic; full source architecture carried forward)
- WP-2026-MAXPRESS-01 — Maximum-pressure implementation: secondary-sanctions readiness, EO 13846, CISADA

- WP-2026-UNIFIED-01 — Integrated financial isolation: Section 311, forfeiture, interagency coordination
- WP-2026-CONTAIN-01 — Long-term non-kinetic containment under multipolar shielding
- WP-2026-INFRA-01 — OSINT-gated enforcement predicates: AIS linkage, BIS/OFAC sequencing, Section 314(a)

[Tier 1 — Government and Treaty Sources]:

- UN Charter Articles 2(4), 42, 51 — Jus ad bellum framework
- UNCLOS Articles 37–44 (transit passage); Article 38 specifically
- Hague Regulations (1907) Articles 42–56 (belligerent occupation); Hague Convention VIII (1907) (naval mines)
- Geneva Convention IV (1949) — Civilian protection under occupation and armed conflict
- U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA) — Strait of Hormuz chokepoint data; Short-Term Energy Outlook (2026); Persian Gulf spare capacity assessments
- Defense Intelligence Agency (DIA) — Iran naval mine inventory estimates (2019; cited in open-source reporting)
- IMO Traffic Separation Scheme — Strait of Hormuz configuration and authority
- OFAC — Iran-related designation lists; secondary sanctions authority under IEEPA and CISADA

[Tier 2 — Established Research and Policy Organizations]:

- Atlantic Council Energy Source — Gulf energy crisis assessments (March 2026)
- CSIS Nuclear Network and Energy Security Program — Iran regional assessment materials
- NTI (Nuclear Threat Initiative) — Iran conventional forces overview
- Strauss Center — Strait of Hormuz geography and bathymetry
- JP Morgan energy analysis — Kharg Island operational capacity (March 2026)
- Operation Earnest Will (1987–88) — Naval escort, burden-sharing, and ROE precedent; documented in Naval Institute Press and DoD historical records
- Abraham Accords normalization framework (2020) — UAE, Bahrain, Sudan, Morocco; documented in State Department public records
- OSCE confidence-building architecture — Helsinki Final Act (1975) and subsequent OSCE documentation; institutional model for Gulf Maritime Forum proposal
- Saudi Vision 2030 Mining Pillar — Ma'aden and Saudi Ministry of Industry public documentation; $110B initiative
- UAE Manara Minerals / IRH Fund — Public reporting on overseas critical minerals acquisition strategy
- IRGC economic holdings — Khatam al-Anbiya open-source estimates; Transparency for Iran and UANI research products

[Tier 2 — Major Media with Named Institutional Sources]:

- Axios — U.S. government Kharg Island contingency discussions (March 8, 2026); DFC insurance backstop announcement (March 3, 2026). Treated as Tier 2 with Tier 3 verification uncertainty — claims dependent on this reporting are labeled at point of use.

- GlobalSecurity.org / RFE/RL — UAE island sovereignty claim; Chinese diplomatic position (December 2025)
- Reuters / Financial Times — China rare earth export data; China-Iran trade volume estimates (2025–2026)

PART X: POST-SEIZURE PHASE ASSESSMENT — KHARG ISLAND

NOTE ON ANALYTICAL STATUS: Parts I–IX of this document constitute a pre-seizure scenario architecture. This section addresses the divergence between that architecture and actual events as of March 2026, in which Kharg Island has been substantially destroyed by aerial bombardment and the United States has moved to take physical control of the facility. This section is forward-looking: it addresses what the post-seizure phase requires analytically, what obligations are now operative rather than hypothetical, and how the pre-seizure architecture must be adjusted to remain relevant. The pre-seizure analysis in Parts I–IX stands as a valid analytic baseline; its role has shifted from prescriptive architecture to documented counterfactual against which actual events can be assessed.

ANALYTIC STATUS OF THIS SECTION	*All claims in this section are either: documented open-source observation of events that have occurred, analytically inferred from the post-seizure condition, or scenario-conditioned projections of forward requirements. The legal characterization of the seizure as unlawful under international law is treated here as a legally contested question on which reasonable positions differ — not as a settled determination. The document's role is to analyze the obligations and burdens that attach regardless of how the legal contest is resolved, because those obligations are operative whether or not the seizure is ultimately characterized as lawful.*

10.1 The Pre-Seizure Analysis Was Correct About the Burden — The Burden Is Now Operative

WP-2026-HORMUZ-01 assessed Posture 3 territorial-control contingencies as carrying substantial escalation, legal, and sustainment burdens. It argued that the coercive leverage created by the threat of Kharg seizure was more strategically valuable than actual seizure, because the threat preserved optionality while actual seizure created obligations. That analytic judgment was sound at the time it was made. The policy decision has now overtaken the analytic recommendation. The relevant question is no longer whether to incur the Posture 3 burden but how to manage obligations that are now accruing.

The document's prior legal analysis of belligerent occupation is now operative rather than hypothetical. Under the Hague Regulations (1907) Articles 42–56 and Geneva Convention IV (1949), the following obligations attach immediately upon effective control of occupied territory and do not diminish with the passage of time — they increase:

- Protection of civilian population: Kharg Island has approximately 10,000 permanent residents. Civilian protection obligations under IHL are operative from the moment of effective control, regardless of the condition of the island's infrastructure.
- Maintenance of public order and safety: the occupying power assumes responsibility for basic public administration, including food, water, medical care, and security. Substantial

bombing damage to infrastructure increases rather than decreases the scope of this obligation.

- Property preservation: destruction of infrastructure prior to or during seizure does not eliminate the obligation to account for property. The condition of the infrastructure affects the operational feasibility of the occupation, not the legal obligations attached to it.
- Revenue disposition: operation of an oil terminal under belligerent occupation generates revenue that under established international law principles belongs to the occupied territory, not the occupying power. If the terminal is inoperable due to bombing damage, this obligation is suspended but not eliminated — it resumes when and if operations resume, and the revenue accounting obligation runs from the moment of effective control.

OCCUPATION LAW STATUS [HIGH CONFIDENCE on legal framework; SCENARIO-CONDITIONED on operational specifics]	*The legal obligations of belligerent occupation attach upon effective control. Substantial prior bombing damage does not reduce these obligations — it increases the administration burden by creating civilian welfare requirements that did not exist before bombardment. The longer the occupation continues, the higher the legal and political cost of exit. There is no historical case of the United States holding Iranian oil infrastructure for an extended period. The exit problem begins accruing from day one of effective control.*

10.2 What the Post-Seizure Architecture Requires

The pre-seizure architecture assumed that Posture 2 — reinforced distributed posture without territorial control — was the baseline recommended course, with Posture 3 maintained as a coercive branch. With Posture 3 now activated, the architecture must address five forward requirements that were previously conditional.

10.2.1 Infrastructure Assessment and Civilian Welfare

ASSESSMENT [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]: The immediate post-seizure requirement is a rapid infrastructure assessment to determine: the condition of the seven main loading jetties and remote mooring facilities; the operational status of the five submarine pipelines from mainland Khuzestan oil fields; the condition of the 28–30 million barrel onboard storage capacity; and the civilian welfare situation for the island's approximately 10,000 permanent residents. The bombing damage assessment is the baseline from which all subsequent decisions — operational, legal, and diplomatic — flow. Without it, neither the revenue disposition problem nor the civilian protection obligation can be properly scoped.

The 20–23 day onboard storage buffer identified in WP-2026-HORMUZ-01 as the operative window before mainland pipeline disruption becomes critical is now a live operational constraint rather than a scenario parameter. If the submarine pipelines from mainland Khuzestan have been damaged or if Iran has severed mainland crude supply, the storage buffer begins depleting immediately. This was the principal structural vulnerability identified in the pre-seizure analysis, and it remains the most operationally significant constraint on the viability of any extended occupation.

10.2.2 Revenue Disposition and Legal Structure

ASSESSMENT [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]: If Kharg terminal operations resume under U.S. effective control, the revenue generated requires a legal disposition structure analogous to the UN Oil-for-Food mechanism — with all the complexity and

political liability that implies. The options are limited: revenue held in escrow pending legal resolution; revenue directed to a UN-administered humanitarian fund; revenue applied to civilian welfare obligations on the island; or revenue credited against a future settlement. Each option creates its own legal and political complications. The absence of a pre-planned revenue disposition structure is the single most predictable administrative failure mode of an extended occupation, and it should be addressed before operations resume rather than after revenue begins accruing.

10.2.3 Partner Political Calculus Revision

ASSESSMENT [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE-HIGH CONFIDENCE]: The partner political calculus changes qualitatively when the U.S. is in physical control of Iranian territory rather than conducting maritime security operations. GCC partners who were willing to host U.S. forces for escort and MCM operations face a different domestic political calculation when hosting a state that is a belligerent occupier of another regional state's territory. The specific partner impacts:

- Qatar: hosting AFCENT at Al Udeid while the U.S. conducts belligerent occupation of Iranian oil infrastructure creates domestic political pressure that the June 2025 missile strike precedent had already elevated. Qatar's independent Iran trade and diplomatic relationship makes this politically more costly than the pre-seizure posture.
- UAE: the UAE island sovereignty claim over Abu Musa and the Tunbs creates a structural alignment with U.S. willingness to exercise territorial control in the Gulf — but also creates a precedent problem. UAE cannot publicly endorse U.S. seizure of Kharg without implicitly endorsing territorial seizure as an acceptable instrument in Gulf territorial disputes, which is a double-edged precedent given UAE's own contested claims.
- Saudi Arabia: the Saudi treaty negotiation is now occurring in the context of active U.S. belligerent occupation in the Gulf. This changes Saudi risk calculus — Saudi Arabia must assess whether being in a formal defense treaty with the U.S. creates an entanglement risk in the current occupation that it does not want. This may accelerate or decelerate the treaty negotiation depending on Saudi domestic political dynamics not fully visible from open sources.
- Oman: Oman's back-channel value to the U.S. is now higher than before the seizure, not lower, because Iran's diplomatic options have narrowed and Oman is one of the few remaining channels through which any communication can occur. But Oman's willingness to serve as intermediary when the U.S. is in belligerent occupation of Iranian territory is a significant political ask of a state that derives its value from neutrality.

10.2.4 Diplomatic Sequencing Under Occupation Conditions

ASSESSMENT [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, LOW-MODERATE CONFIDENCE]: The Hormuz Transit Conference and Gulf Maritime Forum pathway assumed a baseline in which the U.S. had not physically seized Iranian territory. With seizure underway, Iran's domestic political constraints on any negotiation harden substantially. No Iranian government can negotiate from a position of acknowledged territorial loss without regime-threatening domestic political cost. The Iranian government's public posture will be non-negotiation until territorial restoration — regardless of what private back-channel communications indicate.

The diplomatic sequencing must therefore be reframed. The Track 1 back-channel objective changes from 'halt mine-laying in exchange for no-seizure assurance' — which is no longer available because seizure has occurred — to 'establish the terms under which a negotiated end

to occupation is possible.' That is a harder negotiation because the U.S. is now the party that must define its exit conditions, and any exit conditions that appear to concede the seizure's illegality create domestic political costs in the U.S. while any exit conditions that appear to ratify the seizure create domestic political costs in Iran. The diplomatic sequencing must be designed to provide both governments with an exit that is domestically defensible — which historically requires either a face-saving formula or a third-party mediation framework that allows both sides to characterize the outcome differently to domestic audiences.

Oman and Switzerland remain the most viable back-channel mechanisms for this reframed objective. The UN Security Council is not a viable forum given Russian and Chinese veto dynamics. The ICJ is a long-horizon legal instrument, not a crisis-management tool. The most historically relevant precedent is the 1981 Algiers Accords structure used to resolve the Iran hostage crisis — a formula in which both sides could characterize the outcome as a victory to domestic audiences while achieving a functional resolution. A comparable formula structure is likely to be required for any negotiated occupation exit. [LOW CONFIDENCE — dependent on Iranian and U.S. domestic political conditions not observable from open sources]

10.2.5 The Exit Problem

ASSESSMENT [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]: The pre-seizure analysis correctly identified that 'every day of occupation adds to the administration burden and the eventual cost of exit.' That observation is now operative. The exit problem has three dimensions:

- Legal exit: the occupying power must resolve the legal status of the occupation, including revenue disposition, property damage accountability, and civilian protection obligations. These cannot be abandoned; they must be formally resolved in any exit arrangement.
- Operational exit: withdrawing from Kharg while maintaining Hormuz transit security requires that the MCM, escort, and air defense architecture of Posture 2 be fully operational before Posture 3 is wound down. An exit from Kharg that leaves the strait unprotected recreates the original crisis conditions.
- Political exit: the U.S. must be able to characterize the exit as a strategic success, not a retreat. This requires either a negotiated arrangement that produces measurable Iranian behavioral change — reduced mine-laying, transit passage guarantees, IRGC economic constraints — or a coercive outcome that demonstrably achieved its stated objective. An exit without either of these is a reputational cost that affects future deterrence credibility.

EXIT ARCHITECTURE REQUIREMENT [ANALYTICALLY INFERRED, MODERATE CONFIDENCE]	*The occupation should not be conceived as an indefinite condition but as a time-bounded coercive instrument with a defined exit architecture. The pre-seizure analysis recommended treating Kharg as a deterrence threat rather than an execution. That recommendation was analytically correct. Since execution has occurred, the equivalent discipline must now be applied to the exit: define the exit conditions early, build the legal and diplomatic structure for exit before administrative obligations compound further, and ensure that Posture 2 maritime security operations are fully re-established as the operational foundation before territorial withdrawal. A coercive instrument without a defined exit is an occupation without a strategy.*

10.3 Relationship to Pre-Seizure Architecture

The pre-seizure architecture in Parts I–IX remains analytically valid as a description of the strategic logic that should govern the post-seizure phase. The Posture 2 maritime security

framework — MCM, escort, air and missile defense, coalition burden-sharing — is now the operational baseline that must be maintained concurrent with, and eventually as the successor to, the Kharg occupation. The partner architecture and diplomatic sequencing developed in Parts III–V remain the relevant framework for managing coalition cohesion and establishing the diplomatic pathway to occupation exit.

What changes is the time pressure. In the pre-seizure architecture, the diplomatic and coalition management elements could be developed in parallel with military operations over a 1–5 year horizon. In the post-seizure phase, the occupation creates an accelerating cost structure — legal obligations, civilian welfare requirements, revenue disposition complexity, partner political tolerance erosion — that compresses the timeline for diplomatic resolution. The 60-day back-channel activation target in the pre-seizure architecture should be treated as a ceiling, not a planning target, in the post-seizure context.

FINAL ASSESSMENT ON KHARG [MODERATE CONFIDENCE, ANALYTICALLY INFERRED]: The seizure of Kharg Island is a significant escalation that creates substantial legal, administrative, diplomatic, and partner management burdens. The pre-seizure analysis correctly predicted these burdens. Managing them requires: immediate infrastructure and civilian welfare assessment; a pre-planned revenue disposition structure before operations resume; accelerated back-channel activation toward exit terms rather than crisis management; maintenance and reinforcement of the Posture 2 maritime security architecture as the operational foundation for eventual withdrawal; and careful management of partner political tolerance, particularly Qatar, UAE, and Oman, whose cooperation is essential to the exit as well as the occupation. The exit problem is the dominant strategic challenge of the post-seizure phase, and it should be treated as such from day one of effective control.

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